Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Elinor Wylie's "Pretty Words"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the speaker's use of words to express her love of words in Elinor Wylie's "Pretty Words" include

alliteration,
apostrophe,
assonance,
controlling image,
feminine rhyme,
imagery,
melopoeia,
Miltonic sonnet,
metaphor,
octave,
onomatopoeia,
personification,
reification,
rhyme scheme,
sestet,
simile,
speaker,
synæsthesia,
sigmatism,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant might approach this discussion, this analysis, in one of several ways. Each approach has its merits, and because this essay has not been written for the Ready Writing contest, the judges' attention should be paid to content and not to the level of refinement. An appreciation of the essay's organization, for example, should not outweigh the consideration of the essay's analysis of the speaker's use of words. Not all aspects of the speaker's use of words to express her love of words can be covered in a brief essay: the essay's thesis should reflect the writer's particular focus.

The writer's analysis might focus on the speaker's comparisons, which appear as similes (fish, line 2; birds, line 4; and moths and bees, line 13) and metaphors (deer in herds, line 5; kittens, lines 6-8; cattle, line 11), each of which is couched in imagery—visual or tactile or auditory or gustatory.

The writer might chose to focus on the words' melopoeic qualities: the alliteration, the assonance, the sigmatism; the onomatopoeia; and in their use in this poem, synæsthesia (lines 2 and 9), personification (line 9), and reification (lines 1 and 4)—all inseparable from the melopoeic-charged imagery.

The young LitCritter's *point de depart* might be the imagery found throughout the sonnet, or the focus might be the controlling images, short though they be: the octave's kittens and the sestet's bees.

The contestant might recognize that the speaker's comparisons involve the natural world, specifically the animals, only one of which is domesticated—the kittens, words she can make playful (line 6).